

Otto Wagner and Joseph Maria Olbrich

Wagner (1841–1918), who served as Professor of Architecture at the Vienna Academy of Fine Arts, was initially a proponent of neoclassicism, later adopting more modernist ideas. From 1894 to 1910, he designed bridges and stations for the Stadtbahn (Viennese subway system). His restrained, geometric entrance to the Karlsplatz Station was a steel frame with marble slabs in the Stadtbahn colours of green, gold and white. Wagner also created the Austrian Postal Savings Bank, using aluminium, glass and marble in an airy and elegant structure.

Wagner's student Joseph Maria Olbrich (1867–1908) became the leading architect of the Vienna Secession and was chosen to design the group's exhibition hall (opposite, 1897). Loosely following the rectilinear style of Mackintosh, the hall is bold and simple, comprising large white rectilinear forms topped by a golden metal cupola of floral openwork. The building won much acclaim, and Olbrich was commissioned to help design the Darmstadt Artists' Colony in Hesse, Germany in 1899–1901.

